

Session 26: The Upside-Down Character of Jonah

Key Takeaways

- In the book of Jonah, everything is upside-down, and every character reverses their stereotypical behavior, including the pagans and Jonah. The only person who is true to form is God.
- The phrase “the uttermost parts of the ship” is a clever wordplay on a well-known phrase for the cosmic mountain of God that is associated with Eden, “the uttermost reaches of the north” ([Ps. 48](#)).

Jonah’s Flight to a Pseudo-Eden

Jonah’s flight ([Jon. 1:3](#)) introduces a major theme in [chapter 1](#) that comically inverts a standard biblical motif: humans exiled from Eden because of their attempt to recreate their own version of Eden in high places or gardens and with wealth or wisdom.

Jonah, on the other hand, goes down instead of up, and he runs toward death instead of life.

Jonah’s “Descent” Into Death

Jonah 1:3a NASB*

Jonah **went down** (*yarad*) to Joppa (*yapho*).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Went down” = *yarad* = יָרַד

Jonah 1:3b NASB*

Jonah **went down** (*yarad*) into the ship.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Went down” = *yarad* = יָרַד

Jonah 1:5 NASB*

Jonah **went down** (*yarad*) into the **uttermost parts of the ship** (*yarketey-hasephinah*), and he lay down and went into a **deep sleep** (*vayeradam*).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Far reaches” = *yarketey* = יָרְכֵתִי

“Deep sleep” = *yeradam* = וַיִּרְדָּם

The triple repetition of “went down” (יָרַד) is echoed by Jonah’s “deep sleep” (וִירְדָם) and the location he seeks upon the ship (יִרְכָתִי). All three of these terms connect to Jonah’s inverted Eden.

“Deep sleep” is associated with a lifeless slumber caused by Yahweh when he does something for the sleeper that they could not do for themselves. This prompts one to wonder: Is Jonah’s deep sleep a kind of judgment? Is Yahweh’s providence taking Jonah “all the way to the bottom”?

Adam’s “Deep Sleep” in Eden

Genesis 2:21 NASB

So the LORD God caused a deep sleep to fall upon the man, and he slept. Then he took one of his sides and closed up the flesh at that place.

Abraham’s “Deep Sleep” When Given the Eden Blessing

Genesis 15:12 NASB

Now when the sun was going down, a deep sleep fell upon Abram; and behold, terror and great darkness fell upon him.

The phrase “the uttermost parts of the ship” is a clever wordplay on a well-known name for the cosmic mountain of God that is associated with Eden, “the uttermost reaches of the north.”

- Uttermost parts of the ship = *yarketey hasephinah* / הספינה ירכתי
- Uttermost reaches of the north = *yarketey hatsaphon* / הצפון ירכתי

“Zaphon, a mountain to the north of Israel, represented a divine abode in the ancient period. Accordingly, Zaphon in the Bible signifies either a heavenly divine location (“I will rise up into the heavens ... I will sit on the mountain of divine assembly, in the upper reaches of Zaphon,” [Isa. 14:13](#)) or to the sacred mountain in Jerusalem (“Mount Zion, the upper reaches of Zaphon,” [Ps. 48:3](#)). The divine mountain, for its part, constitutes a secure, paradisiacal location, one that Ezekiel ... likens to “the garden of God” ([Ezek. 28:13-14](#)). Based on the biblical and comparative evidence, scholars characterize the garden of Eden as an archetypal sanctuary, a place where God dwells and where humans worship him.” Correspondingly, the Israelite temple on Mount Zion is identified with the primeval hill, paradise, the cosmic mountain.”

Berger, Yitzhak (2016). [Jonah in the Shadows of Eden](#). Indiana University Press. 3-4.

“The uttermost reaches of the north” is a biblical phrase with rich overtones of the cosmic mountain range in the far north (Mount Hermon and beyond). This was the mythological realm of the Canaanite deities (see Clifford, 2010). It was an exotic, snowy, high place of the divine realm, where Heaven and Earth overlapped. The biblical authors adopted this phrase and image to describe the temple in Jerusalem, which was an image of Eden, the true cosmic mountain ([Ps. 46](#)).

Psalms 48:1-2 NASB

¹ Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised,
in the city of our God, his holy mountain.

² Beautiful in elevation, the joy of the whole earth,
is Mount Zion, the uttermost reaches of the north,
the city of the great King.

Psalm 46:4-5 NASB

⁴ There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God,
the holy dwelling places of the Most High.

⁵ God is in the midst of her, she will not be moved;
God will help her when morning dawns.

Isaiah depicts the spiritual power behind Babylon as a divine rebel who attempted to ascend God's throne in Eden, which is called "the uttermost reaches of the north." Isaiah inverts the phrase to describe the "uttermost parts of the grave."

Isaiah 14:13-15 NASB*

¹³ "But you said in your heart,
'I will ascend to the heavens;
I will raise my throne above the stars of God,
And I will sit on the mount of assembly
In the uttermost parts of the north (*yarketey tsaphon*).

¹⁴ I will ascend above the heights of the clouds;
I will make myself like the Most High.'

¹⁵ Nevertheless you will be thrust down to Sheol,
To the uttermost parts of the pit (*yarketey bor*)."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This phrase "uttermost parts of the pit" taps into a widespread motif of descent into the grave as an anti-Eden.

Ezekiel 32:18, 21-23 NASB*

¹⁸ Son of man, wail for the hordes of Egypt and bring it down, her and the daughters of the powerful nations, to the underworld, with those who go down to the pit ...

²¹ The strong among the mighty ones shall speak of him and his helpers from the midst of Sheol, "They have gone down, they lie still, the uncircumcised, slain by the sword."

²² Assyria is there and all her company; her graves are round about her. All of them are slain, fallen down by the sword, ²³ whose graves are set in the uttermost parts of the pit and her company is round about her grave.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The author is portraying the prophet as fleeing the call of Yahweh to the nations only to seek his own self-made version of Eden by turning to the nations. In boarding a ship bound for Tarshish, Jonah is actually beginning his descent into death, and the author cleverly calls Jonah's bed "the uttermost parts of the ship" (that is, north).

This phrase also prepares us to expect a storm, which will humble and threaten to break apart the ships of Tarshish.

God’s Judgment on the Ships of Tarshish

In [Isaiah 2](#) and [Ezekiel 26-27](#), God brings judgment on the nations for building false Edens with the wealth of Tarshish.

Isaiah 2:12, 16 Instructor’s Translation

¹² For Yahweh of armies has a day ... ¹⁶ against all the ships of Tarshish, and against all the desirable ships.

Isaiah 23:1 NASB

Wail, O ships of Tarshish,
for Tyre is destroyed without house or harbor;

Psalms 48:4-5,7 NASB*

⁴ The kings assemble themselves together ...
⁵ They saw and were stunned ...
⁷ With the east wind
you break the ships of Tarshish.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Just as in [Jonah 1:4](#)

Jonah 1 and 3 have been designed to echo the divine judgment on Tyre and the ships of Tarshish in Ezekiel 26-27.

Ezekiel 26-27: The Sailors for Tyre	Jonah 1: The Sailors to Tarshish	Jonah 3: The Ninevites
26:16: And the princes of the sea will go down from upon their thrones (בסאותם מעל) and they will remove their robes (והסירו מעליהם) and their garments of embroidery they will strip off; with trembling they will clothe themselves; they will sit upon the ground (ישבו הארץ על) and shudder		The king rises from his throne (מכסאו), removes his robe (אדרתו ויעבר), and sits in the dust (וישב על האפר).
The Sailors in Ezekiel Going to Tyre and in Jonah Going to Tarshish. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

Ezekiel 26-27: The Sailors for Tyre	Jonah 1: The Sailors to Tarshish	Jonah 3: The Ninevites
nonstop, and they will be appalled at you.		
27:3-4: Tyre, perfect in beauty (יָפִי) ... they perfected your beauty. 27:11: They perfected your beauty (יָפִיד). 28:7: Foreigners will ... defile your beauty (יַפְעֵתְךָ), while the king of Tyre was perfect in beauty (28:12 יָפִי), which gave rise to arrogance in your beauty (28:17 יָפִיד).	1:1-3: Jonah flees to Joppa (יָפוֹ)	
27:8b: Your wise ones, O Tyre, were among you, they were your sailors. 27:9b: All the ships of the sea and their sailors (אֲנִיּוֹת וּמַלְחֵיהֶם הַיָּם) were among you.	1:5-6: The chief of sailors (הַחֹבֵל רֹב) and sailors (מַלְחִים), these words appear only in Ezekiel 27 and Jonah 1.	
27:12: Tarshish was your trader (סַחֲרֶתְךָ) due to the greatness of your wealth (See סַחַר, "trade" in 27:15, 16, 18, 21, 36).	1:3: Jonah paid the fare (שָׂכָר).	
27:23: Haran, Canah, and Eden, traders of Sheba, Assyria, Kilmad, were your traders. 27:25: Ships of Tarshish were carriers of your merchandise, and they were filled and very heavy in the heart of the seas.	Jonah found a ship (אֲנִיָּה) going to Tarshish (תַּרְשִׁישׁ). 2:3: You cast me into the heart of the seas (יָמִים בִּלְבָב).	
<i>The Sailors in Ezekiel Going to Tyre and in Jonah Going to Tarshish.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

Ezekiel 26-27: The Sailors for Tyre	Jonah 1: The Sailors to Tarshish	Jonah 3: The Ninevites
27:26: An east wind broke you in the heart of the seas (רוח הקדים שברך בלב ימים).	1:4: God hurled a great wind (רוח גדולה) upon the sea ... so that the ship considered breaking up (והאניה חשבה להשבר).	4:8: And God appointed an east wind (הקדים רוח), a burning one.
27:27: Your wealth, your wares, your merchandise, your sailors and your pilots, your repairers of seams, your dealers in merchandise and all your men of war who are in you, with all your company that is in your midst, will fall into the heart of the seas on the day of your downfall.	1:5: And the sailors ... hurled the cargo in the ship into the sea to lighten from upon them.	
27:28-30: At the sound of the cry of your sailors (זעקת חבליך) the pasture lands will shake. All who handle the oar, the sailors and all the pilots of the sea will come down from their ships. They will stand on the land, and they will make their voice heard over you, and will cry (ויזעקו) bitterly. They will cast dust on their heads. They will wallow in ashes (באפר).	1:5: And the sailors cried out (ויזעקו) each to his god.	3:6: The king of Nineveh sat upon the ashes (האפר) and he cried (ויעזק) out.
27:31: Also they will make themselves bald for you and gird themselves with sackcloth (שקים). And they will weep for you in bitterness of soul with bitter mourning.		3:7-8: Let human and animal ... clothe themselves with sackcloth (שקים).
The Sailors in Ezekiel Going to Tyre and in Jonah Going to Tarshish. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

These hyperlinks bring perspective to Jonah's flight and the portrayal of the sailors and Ninevites.

Tyre and Its Sailors

In Ezekiel 26-27, Tyre was using the sailors and ships of Tarshish (among other places) to bring Eden-like wealth, security, and abundance to their "rock" (רֹכֶס = Tyre) in the "heart of the seas" (Ezek. 27:4). But God will reverse all of their wealth, sending storms to break their ships so that all the sailors cry out in grief, sit in the dust, and mourn over Tyre's lost wealth.

Jonah and the Sailors

Jonah is fleeing to his own pseudo-Eden by heading to Tarshish (on Tyre's fleet) and paying its fare, but God sends a storm to humble his wayward prophet so that the sailors cry out in fear.

The Sailors and the Ninevites

Because the design of Jonah sets the response of the sailors in parallel with the response of the Ninevites, and both of these groups are contrasted with Jonah, it makes perfect sense that the grief and crying out of Tyre's sailors would be applied to the sailors of Tarshish and the Ninevites. Both imitate the crying and grief of the sailors in Ezekiel 26-27.

"In this sequence of prophecies [Ezekiel 26-28], the prophet compares the glamorous Tyre, a kingdom supplied and signified by ships of Tarshish, to the divine mountain and the garden of Eden. If, accordingly, Jonah occupies a Tarshish-bound vessel that stands in parallel to those ships, this yields ... evidence that our protagonist seeks an Eden-like realm of the kind that Ezekiel describes."

Berger, Yitzhak (2016). [*Jonah in the Shadows of Eden*](#). Indiana University Press. 5.

"As for Jonah having provided the *sakar* of the vessel ('its fare') ... consider the familiar motif of treasure-laden ships of Tarshish ... Every biblical reference to the ships of Tarshish signal this luxuriant motif, none more emphatically than Ezekiel 27. [With these associations] the clause in Jonah 'he provided its fare,' much like the place name 'Joppa' (יָפוֹ // יָפִי 'beauty'), gives rise to a highly consequential secondary meaning: In stocking/providing the vessel's fare, a fleeing Jonah, pursuing the idyllic realm that ships of Tarshish supply and signify, hastily provided the ship with the fortune it is destined to carry. The text suggests that the prophet, seeking to escape toward that paradisiacal domain of Tarshish, started out in pursuit of that 'beautiful' (יָפִי) location."

Berger, Yitzhak (2016). [*Jonah in the Shadows of Eden*](#). Indiana University Press. 6-7.

Jonah's Prophetic Failure vs. the Sailors' Spiritual Intuition

Jonah is portrayed as selfish and slow to understand the reality of his situation, while the sailors are depicted as spiritually aware and more in tune with Jonah's God than Jonah is.

Jonah's hypocritical confession in 1:9 shows that he is totally unaware of the contradiction between his actions and his words.

Jonah 1:9 NASB*

I fear Yahweh, the God of the heavens, who made the sea and the dry land.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 95:3, 5 NIV*

³ Yahweh is a great God ...

⁵ The sea is his, for he made it,
and the dry land, his hands formed it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The irony is that Jonah's confession of his "beliefs" is likely based on the formulation of [Psalm 95](#), but this psalm is a call for Israel not to rebel against their God precisely because he is the creator and ruler of all—the very thing Jonah is doing as he quotes these words.

Interpretive Ambiguity

Is Jonah's confession in 1:9 an indirect admission of guilt?

"This is not an empty declaration that Jonah worships the Lord ('fear' or 'awe' in the conventional meaning of fealty and obedience) ... It is rather implicit acknowledgment of his personal responsibility for their predicament because he falls under the direct jurisdiction of the God of sky and sea, therefore the punitive action—the storm—is clearly directed against him."

Simon, Uriel (1999). [JPS Bible Commentary: Jonah](#). Jewish Publication Society. 12.

"The implication of the confession of faith is that the source of the storm is none other than Yahweh who made the sea. The wonder is that Jonah can recite such a creed and yet show disrespect to the commands of the God whose sovereignty it celebrates."

Allen, Leslie C. (1976). [The Books of Joel, Obadiah, Jonah, and Micah](#). Eerdmans. 210.

In contrast, the sailors' prayer to God in 1:14 quotes from the psalms and has the opposite effect.

Jonah 1:14 Instructor's Translation

Please Yahweh, don't let us perish on account of this man's life ... for just as you have purposed, you have done.

Psalms 115:2-3 NASB*

² Why should the nations say,

"Where now is your God?"

³ Our God is in the heavens,
And everything which he purposes, he does.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 135:5-6 NIV*

⁵ I know that Yahweh is great,
and our Lord is greater than all gods.

⁶ Everything which he purposes, Yahweh does
in the heavens, on the land,
in the seas and all the depths.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The irony is that Jonah confessed to believe in the “God of the heavens,” yet it is the sailors who actually understand the implications of such a belief. They recognize the storm as God’s purpose and a result of his power over the sea.

“In both psalms, the confession of faith contrasts Yahweh with other, impotent gods ([135:5](#)) and idols ([115:4-7](#)) ... In this way—through the prayer in general and through its individual phrases—the narrator depicts the heathen sailors as people who turn to Yahweh like model Israelites, at least where Jonah’s affairs are concerned, and when they are in danger of shipwreck.”

Wolff, Hans Walter (1986). [Obadiah and Jonah: A Commentary](#). Augsburg Fortress Pub. 120.

Reflection Question

Recall the page from the children’s magazine *Highlights* called “What’s Wrong?” where readers are challenged to find everything that’s not quite right in the picture. What do you find helpful about this example? Is there a different example or illustration that would help those in your context understand how the author of Jonah is subverting or playing with reader expectations?